DRIVE TO VICTORY

THE AMERICAN WAR EFFORT in the Pacific began inexorably to gather momentum after 1943. At first naval action was confined to relatively small-scale engagements around the Solomons and in the North Pacific, but from November 1943 the United States began a drive through the Central Pacific to the Marshall and Mariana Islands, and from New Guinea to the Philippines. Attempting to resist this advance, the Japanese navy committed its forces to major battles at the Philippine Sea and Leyte Gulf. These epic engagements revealed the overwhelming naval superiority the Americans had achieved by this stage in the war. After Leyte Gulf the Japanese navy could only put up meaningful resistance by operating naval aircraft from land bases. Using kamikaze tactics they inflicted heavy losses on the Allied fleet at Okinawa in 1945, but by then Japan had already lost the naval war.

THE WAR IN THE PACIFIC 1943–1945

By late 1943 the tide of the Pacific War had turned and the US Navy began its long, inexorable advance through the Pacific toward Japan, one island to the next. The destruction of the Japanese Navy and naval aviation at Leyte Gulf and the Philippine Sea opened the way to the Japanese home islands.

KEY

- Area under Japanese control Jan 1943
- US/Allied landing/advance
- US/Allied victory
- Inconclusive battle



WORLD WAR II

BISMARCK SEA



Date March 2–3, 1943
Forces Americans: 168 aircraft; Japanese: 8 destroyers, 8 transports
Losses Americans: 5 aircraft; Japanese: 4 destroyers, 8 transports

Location Off Papua New Guinea, Bismarck Sea

In 1943 the Allies installed elements of the US 5th Army Air Force and the Royal Australian Air Force at bases on New Guinea to intercept Japanese convoys ferrying troops from their base at Rabaul across the Bismarck Sea. On March 1, 1943, a convoy of eight Japanese troop transports with destroyer escorts, under Rear Admiral Masatomi Kimura, was spotted heading for Lae in New Guinea. One transport was sunk by B-17 bombers on March 2, but the main air strike was delivered on the morning of March 3. American B-25 Mitchell bombers and Australian Bristol Beaufighters attacked at low altitude with torpedoes, "skip" bombs—released onto the water to bounce into their target—and strafing guns.

The destroyers *Shirayuki*, *Arashio*, *Tokitsukaze*, and *Asashio* were sunk, along with all the troop transports. On the day after the battle Allied aircraft and torpedo boats systematically machine-gunned Japanese survivors in the water. Almost 2,900 Japanese soldiers and sailors were killed in what General Douglas MacArthur described as "one of the most complete and annihilating combats of all time."

WORLD WAR II

KOMANDORSKI ISLANDS



Date March 27, 1943
Forces Americans: 2 cruisers, 4 destroyers; Japanese: 4 cruisers, 4 destroyers
Losses Americans: none; Japanese: none

Location South of Komandorski Islands, North Pacific

The heavy cruiser *Salt Lake City*, the light cruiser *Richmond*, and four American destroyers, all commanded by Rear Admiral Charles McMorris, were sent into the North Pacific to block the path of a Japanese convoy bound for the Aleutian Islands. McMorris encountered the convoy on March 27, only to find it escorted by a stronger force of warships than his own. Vice Admiral Boshiro Hosogaya had the heavy cruisers *Nachi* and *Maya*, plus light cruisers and destroyers.

The Americans first steamed toward the convoy, but soon judged it wiser to stage a fighting withdrawal. *Nachi* was the first ship hit, but *Salt Lake City* ran into serious difficulties as the shelling intensified, losing steering and power. As she sat dead in the water, the US destroyers laid a protective smokescreen in front of her and launched torpedo attacks against the Japanese cruisers while under heavy fire. *Salt Lake City* fortunately got her engines restarted and the Japanese turned away, short of ammunition and fuel. This inconclusive encounter was one of the last in naval history in which large ships battled almost exclusively with gunnery.

WORLD WAR II

KULA GULF



Date July 6, 1943
Forces Americans: 3 cruisers, 4 destroyers; Japanese: 10 destroyers
Losses Americans: 1 cruiser; Japanese: 2 destroyers

Location Solomon Islands, South Pacific

In summer 1943 the Americans were fighting for control of the Solomons. On the night of July 5-6 10 Japanese destroyers commanded by Rear Admiral Teruo Akiyama on board *Niizuki*, were carrying reinforcements to Kolombangara Island. This "Tokyo Express" was intercepted by Rear Admiral Walden Ainsworth's force of light cruisers and destroyers. The Japanese, newly equipped with search radar, spotted the Americans first and three destroyers turned for a torpedo run. *Niizuki* was hit by radar-directed fire from the US cruisers and sank, with Admiral Akiyama among those killed. But the two other destroyers fired longlance torpedoes before turning away. The cruiser *Helena* was struck by several torpedoes and sank. Another Japanese destroyer ran aground and was demolished by American aircraft after daylight, leaving honours roughly even.

WORLD WAR II

EMPRESS AUGUSTA BAY



Date November 2, 1943
Forces Americans: 4 cruisers, 8 destroyers; Japanese: 4 cruisers, 6 destroyers
Losses Americans: none; Japanese: 1 cruiser, 1 destroyer

Location Off Bougainville Island, South Pacific

On November 1, 1943, 14,000 US Marines were landed on Bougainville in the Solomon Islands. In response the Japanese sent a hastily assembled naval force from Rabaul under Admiral Sentaro Omori. American light cruisers and destroyers commanded by Rear Admiral Aaron "Tip" Merrill took up position to defend the landings. In principle the Japanese force was much the stronger, as it included the heavy cruisers *Myoko* and *Haguro*. Both sides engaged in complex maneuvers in the dark, creating considerable confusion.

The US destroyer *Foote* lost touch with its formation and was hit by a stray torpedo that blew off the back of the ship, although she was eventually towed to safety. Various Japanese ships careered just past or into one another, *Myoko* slicing through the destroyer *Hatsukaze*—she carried the destroyer's bow back to port with her. The light cruiser *Sendai* was disabled by multiple hits from American guns, but in general both sides expended shells to little effect. *Omori* broke off the engagement before daybreak, convinced he had inflicted far more damage than was actually the case. *Sendai* and *Hatsukaze* were left behind to be finished off by the Americans. Several hundred Japanese were killed in the engagement; 19 American lives were lost.